

## Decolonial Entanglements

This book responds to a critical geopolitical moment where decolonial thought, praxis, and pedagogy confront urgent questions of resistance in the face of Palestinian genocide and scholasticide, alongside other forms of state-sanctioned colonial violence against Black, Indigenous, immigrant, and displaced peoples worldwide.

Establishing solidarity across diverse movements, while respecting their unique histories and contexts, this volume embraces relational methodologies that foster dissent, points of tension, and conjunctures, and at the same time advances pedagogical practices aimed toward coalition-building. By bringing together anticolonial concepts, decolonial methodologies, and abolitionist thought, it challenges colonial systems of knowledge amplifying theoretical frameworks and practical pedagogical approaches that center knowledge rooted in collective struggles and movements. Together, the chapters serve to emphasize interconnectedness among distinct liberation projects, and to offer a shared vision for decolonial futures grounded in pedagogies of solidarity and internationalism.

Essential for academics and graduate students in decolonial and abolitionist studies in education, international and comparative education, philosophy and sociology of education, and globalization studies.

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## **Decolonial Entanglements**

Series Editors: Jairo I. Fúnez-Flores, Ana Carolina Díaz Beltrán, and Nathalia E. Jaramillo

This series advances the latest scholarship that draws on and builds upon decolonial thought and praxis with an acute focus on pedagogical and transdisciplinary aspects within and beyond formal educational institutions. It takes a transdisciplinary approach by featuring the work of scholars who, on the one hand, advance theory that unsettles disciplinary boundaries, and, on the other, take a praxis-oriented mode of theorizing education, curriculum, and pedagogy alongside sites of struggle. Invited topics include - but are not limited to - decolonial thought in curriculum theory and the philosophy of education, decolonial feminist pedagogies, and analyses and critiques of racial capitalism.

Publishing both single-authored and edited volumes from established and early-career scholars alike, it amplifies decolonial discourses and practices emerging from regions often left out of the conversation in dominant academic spaces. It therefore seeks to broaden the understanding of decolonial theories while pointing to a planetary understanding of colonial structures and histories. Moreover, it highlights the theories and praxes emerging from distinct yet historically connected geographies. It will include transdisciplinary contributions that advance genealogical, theoretical, methodological, and empirical studies that make explicit the geopolitical, economic, social, and cultural intimacies across geographical boundaries.

## **Decolonial Entanglements**

Praxis, Pedagogy, and Social Theory

*Edited by Jairo I. Fúnez-Flores, Ana Carolina Díaz Beltrán, and Nathalia E. Jaramillo*



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**Edited by Jairo I. Fúnez-Flores,  
Ana Carolina Díaz Beltrán,  
and Nathalia E. Jaramillo**

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## 4 Decolonial Pedagogy and Praxis in a Time of Live-Streamed Genocide

Dialogic Notes from a Global  
North Classroom

*Usha Iyer and Sophie D'Souza*

In this chapter, we reflect on the experience of participating – as an instructor and a graduate student – in the seminar, “Decolonization and Decoloniality: Theory, Praxis, and Pedagogy” at Stanford University in Spring 2024. This seminar took place during the peak of the student intifada, protesting the genocide in Gaza and the occupation of Palestine. At Stanford, the movement took the forms of the university’s longest-ever 120-day sit-in, followed by a two-month encampment, “The People’s University for Palestine,” and the occupation of the president’s office for a morning by a group of students who were then arrested, suspended, and charged with felonies. While there is now a vital and vibrant body of scholarship on decolonial theory and praxis, this chapter centers decolonial pedagogy, delving into the shifts produced in teaching and learning when political movements radically alter the conditions in which pedagogy takes place. We ask, what does a feminist, combative, killjoy decolonial pedagogy look like in a university shot through with the insurgent energies of the student intifada?<sup>1</sup> Embodying the dialogic mode of a learning community composed of what Paolo Freire (1970) called teacher-students and student-teachers, rather than centering the voice of the professor, we alternate between our reflections as professor and student, as well as those of other seminar participants. Together, we consider the affordances of decolonial pedagogy, praxis, and theory during an extended period of spectacular state violence.

Through the form of dialogic journal entries, we capture how, given the seminar’s emphasis on decolonial praxis and pedagogy and our own political commitments, the instructor and many seminar participants felt the urgent need to shape our seminar in response to the events unfolding around us, as the U.S. and the Zionist entity continued/s their brutal genocide in Gaza (Salaita, 2024). As a group, we were pressed to connect our weekly readings, films, and workshops with the uprisings on campuses and on the streets. As Silvia Rivera Cusicanqui observes, “There can be no discourse of decolonization, no theory of decolonization, without a decolonizing

practice” (2012, p. 100). As we read Cusicanqui, Abdaljawad Omar, Linda Tuhiwai Smith, Steven Salaita, and others, and as we engaged with critical university studies, we interrogated the relations and gaps between the classroom and the streets, the potential and limits of the university, not to mention the very structures and strictures of graduate training in an elite private institution. For the majority of women of color in the seminar, our central investment was to think about how education might be put to radical uses, and how decolonial theories and pedagogies might foster revolutionary and liberatory energies. Through those three months together, continuing into the present moment, we ask, where do we go from here? And how far are we willing to go? These questions point to the horizons that an insurgent decolonial pedagogy might bring into view, and call for deeper engagement with the ways in which decolonial theory and praxis shape the classroom and the worker-scholar-combatants within it.

**Sophie:** In Spring 2024, graduate students at a university with the third-largest endowment among US universities, gathered in a windowless basement meeting room for the first session of a seminar titled “Decolonization and Decoloniality: Theory, Praxis, and Pedagogy.” We write today submerged in the belly of the beast as it continues its collaboration with the Zionist entity to commit genocide against the people, animals, plants, land, air, and water of Gaza. With images of strewn limbs, shredded sinews, beheaded infants burned into the minds of anyone with a smartphone, there are many moments and days where words feel futile. I ask myself, how does writing a book chapter mend the heart of the grandfather who sat alone amidst the bodies of his family members in the rubble of the home he built? Or resurrect the son who never returned home to his mother? How can it restore a chance at life to the 274 babies who were killed in Gaza on the day they were born? It cannot remedy the pain of the flesh. Yet, we write to archive this time, to preserve memory, and to name the colonial conditions that produce such wounding. We write to share how this moment of prolonged and unrelenting violence expanded the bounds of the classroom beyond the basement seminar room and into other contested terrains.

We write to remember how the elite private university responded when it was called to stand up. We write to hold the tension that, in times of genocide, the classroom is simultaneously a meaningless and a profoundly transformative endeavor, worth nurturing as well as uprooting. Demanding better from ourselves, from each other, and from our institutions – while being under no illusions of their loyalty to the colonial enterprise (including



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the quiet places within us that may unknowingly harbor similar allegiances) – requires that we also reckon with our own imperfect solidarities.

\*

*Seminar participant: “The seminar title called people who were otherwise spread out across campus into one space, but there were definitely complexities even amidst us.”*

\*

**Usha:** Trained as a scholar of film and media of the global majority (primarily South Asia and the Caribbean), on the two occasions I taught graduate seminars on decoloniality, I have noticed that the particular energies of this course – generated by the readings, the students who are drawn to the material, and events in the world around us – are very different from my other seminars. We go on a journey that not everyone may like all parts of, but the hope is that something has been transformed in each of us as a result of this encounter. The stakes of anti-colonial and decolonial scholarship profoundly alter pedagogical practice. Rather than focus only on decolonial theory as one more site for extractive reading in the PhD curriculum, the course moved us to ask how we might disrupt the professionalizing aims of the graduate seminar to produce a different sociality in the university and reconsider the place of the classroom in larger liberation struggles. And so, I entered the spring 2024 iteration with Maria Lugones’s words as a guide: “Decolonizing gender is necessarily a praxical task. ... As such it places the theorizer in the midst of people” (Lugones, 2010, p. 746).

Our seminar had participants from Chile, Crimea, Venezuela, Nigeria, Puerto Rico, India, Trinidad, Zimbabwe, Romania, Iran, the United Kingdom, the United States (South, East, Midwest) etc., each of us bringing different histories and experience to the course materials, invited/forced to reckon with the generative and fractious power of difference in the classroom. In a spirit of anti-essentialist and anti-assimilative proliferation, participants were invited to speak from their locations and histories and write weekly posts in multiple languages. Meanwhile, the syllabus included work by Latin-American, Maori, Dalit, African, Afro-diasporic, Mohawk, and other scholars and filmmakers. The embodied presence of students from such a diverse range of geographies sharpened the provenance and location of course materials within their contexts, lineages, and the varied conditions

of production of knowledge, all serving to decenter, to unsettle the Euro-U.S. academy and its settled and settling canons. As an Iranian student bemoaned the central focus on European colonialism in the texts that left out histories of their native regions, or a Venezuelan student articulated the complexity of being caught between multiple oppressive regimes, all these histories and positionalities came into unruly relation, pointing to the need for decolonial scholarship to emerge from a range of histories and to speak from multiple locations. We were alert to the ways in which we are differently materialized and corporealized in the classroom, as well as the need to parse relational networks across diverse locations and traditions with nuanced attention to local meanings, histories, and hierarchies. To understand difference, as Anjali Arondekar and Geeta Patel guided us, not as “simplistic expansion into sites of alterity to reach a whole but as resistance to any form of totalizing knowledge” (2016, p. 155)

**Sophie:** My own experiences navigating the jarring dilemmas wrought in elite colonial universities with the echoes of imperial violence resounding in my own intergenerational memory undoubtedly led me to decolonial thought. My epistemic position is undeniably influenced by the grief and joy of my own diasporic experiences – characterized by a longing to be reconciled with my home place outside of the imperial core, yet separated symbolically and materially. In the seminar space, we navigated the ways in which we arrived at this work, how we were differently embodied, and the need to find relational webs across these varied locations. The tensions and power relations imbued in these surfaced between us as the genocide made its way into our gatherings with mounting urgency.

Many of us in the class understood decoloniality to involve a commitment to engaging in material struggles against colonialism, whilst others’ learning goals were to grow their theoretical literacy within the classroom walls. Turner Prize 2024 winner, Jasleen Kaur, quoted Fred Moten in her acceptance speech: “there’s a difference between the expression of solidarity and the practice of solidarity” (Artists for Palestine UK, 2024). This tension was felt in different participants’ desire for a decolonial pedagogy rooted in practice over theorization, born from a need to resist the co-optation of radical thought into forms that kept us only at the level of intellectual debate, instead of allowing radical thought to move our bodies for liberation. We discussed how decolonial perspectives can be strategically subsumed into the architecture of the academy. The institutionalization of decoloniality forces its true revolutionary charge to be swallowed up by the machinery of the university to be spat out in a less offensive and more palatable form – whether

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through diversity, equity, and inclusion (DEI) initiatives,<sup>2</sup> or a single “indigenous” perspective added on as an optional reading at the end of a syllabus, that ultimately seeks to leave structures undisturbed and unexamined.

In June of 2025, a large crowd gathered for a community vigil to honor and pray for our martyred siblings in Gaza whilst breaking the fast of Arafah in solidarity with Stanford’s 15 hunger strikers. These students abstained from food for 24 days as they demanded complete transparency and principled stewardship of Stanford’s endowment, dropping of the charges against their fellow students charged with felonies, and the rescinding of post-campment speech restrictions. The hunger strikers shared, “we used our bodies to speak when words are ignored” and “I used my body and stomach to bear witness to the suffering of Palestinians.”<sup>3</sup> This form of embodied protest as a mode of resistance foregrounds the importance of corporeal actions in exposing the Zionist entity’s use of starvation, and poisoning food distributed at Gaza’s aid centers as weapons of genocide, as well as the extreme starvation caused by catastrophic food deprivation due to the enforced blockade. The presence of the hunger strike action brought this reality up-close and into glaring focus inside the U.S. university campus.

\*

*Seminar participants:*

*“It was the first space that acknowledged that there was a genocide occurring. It was the first space. No one in our department has said the word, ‘genocide,’ and that I will never forget.”*

*“Engaging the fact that there was a genocide. That’s what made me want to engage in thinking, thinking that is political and productive.”*

\*

**Usha:**

I beg you not to eat us when we die... please... if you stay alive after we die... don’t eat us, our scattered flesh.

Lena, a girl from Gaza, talking to her cat.  
February 19, 2024 (Middle East Eye, 2024)

It is against the production of displaced and shredded corpses that relatives, sons, daughters, fathers, mothers recreate relationships and innovate life. They turn necrophilic settler-colonialism upside down when they breastfeed in a genocide; speak of, collect, hold, gather, and embrace *ashlaa*’.

Nadera Shalhoub-Kevorkian (2024)

What does it mean for our class to watch a film (*Silk Threads*, 2019) by Wala Saada, who has been martyred less than two months prior; to listen to a podcast interview with Nadera Shalhoub-Kevorkian, whom the Zionist entity arrested for her comments on that episode; and to read *Inter/nationalism: Decolonizing Native America and Palestine* by Steven Salaita (2016), who lost his U.S. university job over his pro-Palestine tweets? Through exiled, incarcerated, and murdered scholars and filmmakers, the stakes of and risks surrounding decolonial theory and praxis were put into heightened focus in a time of genocide, especially when engaging with these texts in the belly of the genocidaire state.

What does it mean to read, think, and write in a time of catastrophe? Who is able to, and chooses to continue their lives uninterrupted right now? What does the work of teaching look like under these conditions, when my students and I would rather have been out on the streets, when we found ourselves unable to do close readings during a live-streamed genocide? Extending our discussions of epistemicide were the eviscerating conditions of scholasticide in Gaza (*see* Elhalaby, 2024). The genocide insisted on its presence in the classroom, summoning us to abandon sitting on chairs in air-conditioned seminar rooms to go lie down in a student-organized die-in at the center of campus as the names of entire exterminated families and lineages were read out. We were at the meeting point of epistemic and corporeal disobedience, refusing the disembodied mode mandated for classroom learning in the Kantian-Humboldtian university (*see* Maldonado-Torres, 2024). The bombing of every Gazan university, the specter of a father holding the shattered flesh of his children in two plastic bags, all of it was in the air, for those of us who would smell it. The texture of the classroom changed.

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*Seminar participant: "A genocide is no time for close readings of text. Close readings demand a quiet space, a healthy mind and body, and leisure. Our bodies were not and are still not in this space."*

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**Sophie:** As our universities continue to collaborate with the state, align themselves with profit in exchange for lives, and reproduce corporate neoliberal values of individualism and professionalism, we held to each other to imagine and practice what Maldonado-Torres calls "an-other way" (2024, p. 38) – that is, ways of thinking, acting, and being other than built on the foundations set up by modern Western institutions and their hegemonic structures and epistemologies. Sometimes tentatively, and mostly without total consensus, seminar participants practiced an embodiment

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of affect that is usually contraband in the Western colonial classroom – being moved to dance, grieve, cry, and create together even when “*we didn’t have those walls [of the classroom] to protect us*” (seminar participant).

Against the backdrop of a university that continued to overwork and overburden graduate students, and as we unionized as workers, the social life of class became increasingly fractured. Our diverging commitments to the Palestinian struggle for liberation faced the differential willingness to act and risk the safety and protection promised by the university in exchange for silence and complicity. Some deemed it too risky to move seminar meetings to the student encampment in the middle of campus. Others saw it as the only option - to forego any comfort offered by the university, knowing that the price paid is the blood of Palestinian people. The relations and structures of power were made visible, and people began to notice how they and others were differently implicated and affected by them.

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*Seminar participant: “How can the classroom be a place of feeling seen? Seen in imperfection. A witnessing, a holding.”*

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**Usha:** While, at the start of the quarter, I had described the seminar as having a “living syllabus,” morphing to the shapes wrought by this particular group of interlocutors, I had not quite anticipated how much the structure of the course would change over those three months. Those months were marked by the energies of the student intifada that filled our campus with an electric energy, crackling with rallies and chants, innumerable Palestinian flags flying in the wind, and in quieter moments, the insightful wisdom of student teach-ins, and the joy of cooking and sharing meals in community.

Our seminar, in the meanwhile, manifested vocal conflicts around desires for more emphasis on praxis versus a “depoliticized” theoretical framing of decoloniality. In the past few years, as I keep revisiting my pedagogy, unsettling it, bell hooks’ *Teaching to Transgress* has served as an inspiration for creating an open learning community: “any radical pedagogy must insist that everyone’s presence is acknowledged ... To [some] students, transgressing boundaries was frightening” (2014, p. 8). A majority of the students wanted to move our seminar to the student encampment, and

spent two weeks strenuously building consensus amidst some participants' fears of surveillance. The challenges, anxieties, and rewards of collaboratively shaping a seminar are all part of a decolonial pedagogy of generative uncertainty and discomfort.<sup>4</sup> As we joined what Stefano Harney and Fred Moten call the "gypsy encampment in the university," we had to embrace the undercommons as "always an unsafe neighborhood" (2013, p. 28).

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*Seminar participant: "Moving to the encampment disturbed the commonplace that the classroom should be a 'safe space.' We had to be bold enough to say we wanted to study in a place that was not 'safe,' that was likely surveilled. There's something else that happens when you can't guarantee safety; it helps to situate what you're saying in reality."*

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**Usha:** If decolonization is a project of world-making, what worlds does a classroom engaging with the always unfinished project of decolonization make? What insurrections are possible at the disparate scales of the classroom and of the world? Just as decolonization and decoloniality cannot be state-led projects, they cannot be led by university presidents and deans, or domesticated into a foundation course like the innumerable western civilization freshman courses that proliferate in the US academy. They have to remain a dangerous idea, a risky undertaking for what Frantz Fanon (1963) called anticolonial intellectuals, Edward Said (1991), scholar combatants, Walter Rodney (1990), guerilla intellectuals, and Harney and Moten (2013), subversive intellectuals.

Teaching decolonial thought during a genocide made ever more apparent the need for what Nelson Maldonado-Torres has termed combative decoloniality, which challenges the commodification of radical theory and praxis within the "liberal orbit of the academy" (2024, p. 37), illuminating the "tension between purely scholarly engagements with decoloniality [...] and decoloniality as a living struggle that is part of combative organizing" (2024, p. 40). Extending Cedric Robinson's insistence that "the practice of theory is informed by struggle," Jairo I. Fúnez-Flores describes the insurgent decolonial intellectual as moving "subversively and unpredictably within dominant institutions, such as universities, while working with the insurgencies unfolding beyond" (Fúnez-Flores, 2025). The stakes of doing this work globally are illustrated, for example, in India (my country of birth, and my other home), where professors and students, including G. N. Saibaba, Hani Babu, Anand Teltumbde, and Umar Khalid have been and continue to be brutally incarcerated as political prisoners by the right-wing Hindu majoritarian BJP

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government. To be co-combatants in larger struggles from within the university takes many forms. It is lifelong, patient, un-romantic, un-glamorous work. It is the plodding labor that some campus elders have been doing day after day, in course after course, charged and recharged by a radical love. During these past two years, a feminist, insurgent decolonial pedagogy pushed us not to be just teachers and students, but to also serve as witnesses for students in disciplinary cases, organize alternate graduation ceremonies, put together faculty, staff, and student groups against the genocide, and co-create interdisciplinary courses on Palestine. Through all of this, multiple modes of teaching and learning blossomed within the colonial university. We hadn't felt this exhausted, and this energized in a long time.

**Sophie:** The traditional classroom space became a contested site. Through dancing together in a movement workshop embodying Audre Lorde's (1985) essay, *Poetry is Not a Luxury*, and shuffling willow reed between our hands as we learned to make baskets with a Pomo weaver, we disrupted Eurocentric models of education that demand that graduate students be still, quiet, and resolutely cerebral. Much like the baskets made, our class became a vessel that we wove each week with exchanged smiles, disagreement, conversations about the places, people and ancestors we are from, cups of tea, films in Stanford's dark state-of-the-art cinema rooms, redacted poetry, and sitting on tarpaulin mats. Much like the process of weaving, we could not know what shape the vessel would take but we made it by continuing to struggle against the rigid reeds and bathing them anew in water to allow them to bend and not break.

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*Seminar participants:*

*"Something shifted in the stakes of presenting at the encampment. I'm not just performing intelligence or knowledge in front of these people, but actively trying to engage and share what I don't know."*

*"Outside, sitting in a circle, I could feel generosity from everyone in a different way than in a regular seminar."*

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**Usha:** Teaching a course on decolonization and decoloniality would remain an academic exercise if we didn't go to the "scary," unsettling places of radical disruption, epistemic and material. The task, as our readings and films and workshops reminded us, is to be co-resistors in institutions that do not love us, to rewire

technologies of unfreedom to do freedom work, to “retreat” into the external world. But, as Sara Ahmed (2023) notes, solidarity is a bumpy project. And so the class moved, somewhat impatient with or suspicious of each other as a range of academic and activist desires jammed with and up against each other. We made poems, we danced, we wove baskets, we argued, we reached out to each other in spaces of fugitive study.

A queer feminist decolonial pedagogy is a somatic pedagogy, not only centered around an engagement with written text, but mobilizing, in our seminar, a range of senses and alternative epistemologies through film, movement, weaving, and poetry. Films like *Yadon Ilaheyya* (Divine Intervention, Elia Suleiman, 2002), *Saint Omer* (Alice Diop, 2022), and *Neptune Frost* (Anisia Uzeyman and Saul Williams, 2021) infused with powerful images, sounds, and narrative traditions our discussions of the afterlives of colonialism, occupation, and enslavement. We read Audra Simpson (2007) alongside learning to weave Pomo baskets, we rolled on the studio floor as artist-choreographer Amara Tabor-Smith corporeally unlocked and expanded Audre Lorde’s (2020) call for erotic, sensory learning. We moved our bodies, exploring how we could ask research questions differently. We became Arondekar and Patel’s (2016) epistemic musafirs, intentional conceptual vagabonds.

**Sophie:** What can laboring for freedom in the classroom look like? “The classroom, with all its limitations, remains a location of possibility. In that field of possibility we have the opportunity to labor for freedom, to demand of ourselves and our comrades, an openness of mind and heart that allows us to face reality even as we collectively imagine ways to move beyond boundaries, to transgress. This is education as the practice of freedom,” bell hooks (1994, p. 207) affirms. An education that functions as a situated radical praxis subverts the colonial mode of schooling, or what Freire [1970] refers to as the dominant banking model of education. A liberatory education centers “praxis: the action and reflection of [people] upon their world in order to transform it” (1970, p. 79). It entails the cultivation of experiences where seekers after knowledge may know their reality with greater clarity, and greater conviction to know what must be done, and subsequently, to do it.

**Usha:** In an online discussion on the topic of “Activism & Academic Repression,” Dylan Rodríguez (2024) observes, “academia is this colonial aspirational thing that serves an overarching logic of counterinsurgency by absorbing people who otherwise could be mobilized in terms of their ideas, art, pedagogy, research to make direct contributions to various forms of liberation struggle.” As



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we resolutely maintain our outsider-inside positionality as academic workers, we must constantly ask: how to remain at war, how to remain in hiding (Harney & Moten, 2013, p. 30)? The two might feel contradictory only if we imagine that being at war requires individual visibility as a warrior rather than fighting in community, engaging in radical refusal of institutional demands as wayward laborers, and privileging care networks over the prestige economy of academia. Over the past two years, brazen institutional gaslighting as well as outright repression have galvanized a new energy of radical recalcitrance among many in the professoriate. Our sustained sullenness towards liberal academic panic over freedom of speech in this current moment is born out of a stubborn refusal to consider the US university a privileged and innocent space, and a killjoy determination to not let its complicity in genocide and occupation be swept under “big tent” coalitions.

**Sophie:** We sat together at The People’s University for Palestine transforming existing scholarly texts by selectively shading and reconfiguring its language, unsettling its original narrative to surface new meanings and possibilities from within the words of our assigned authors. Rather than engaging in modes of extractive reading, together we practiced a way of reading that enabled an emergent conversation between the author and the multiple parts – affect, intellect, spirit that make the reader, and then sharing those within our learning community. In conversation with Gopal’s *On Decolonization and the University* (2021), I wrote a redacted poem using a black marker pen to reveal new ideas within/underneath the text as I read my embodied experience at the time of writing through her words on the page. One poem reads

trouble  
the  
sense  
of self  
certitude  
Take  
the damage done to the colonised  
through the imperial enterprise. Decolonisation  
as  
examining how we  
come to know colonial incarnation  
Emerge from  
a horizon of  
multiple directions  
flowing

It was not until later on in the course that I read *Bleeding Forms: Beyond the Intifada* where Abdaljawad Omar writes, “Palestinians have been persisting within a harrowing horizon of annihilation” (2024, p. 311). The horizon appeared again. It instantly reminded me of this redacted poem I created during my poetry workshop a few weeks prior that used the image of a horizon to imagine anticolonial resistance. In this poem, I excavate new meaning as I read Gopal and Omar’s writing, blurring the boundary between the embodied experience of engaging with scholarly texts and the affective insights that these texts evoke. The writing workshop I offered to the group engaged decoloniality as a nimble poetic excursion grounded in the material process of bringing unspoken knowings to the surface, knowings that may have been unuttered or unconstructed until the point that the pen met paper. This pedagogical offering unsettled quiet interior spaces and held a brief moment for seminar participants to intuitively listen to their inner voice in conversation with anticolonial course texts. The line “emerge from a horizon of flowing multiple directions” represents that there is no universal singular decolonial project. Rather, there are multiple manifestations – fractals/tendrils of colonial de-linking charting from multiple different embodied locations, a simultaneous emergence from multiple conjunctures.

**Usha:** As we were drawing to the end of the spring quarter, and it was time for students to work on their final assignments, we interrogated the purpose of this genre to demonstrate mastery, and asked what other types of work might feel meaningful, how might decolonial praxis manifest in a “final project” at the end of a short ten-week quarter. Some of our guiding principles included attending to local histories and contexts, caution with regard to universalizing concepts and frameworks, and considering with rigor each of our own assumed centers and peripheries.

A few weeks later, I would receive final assignments in a magical and staggering range of forms, including a short story set in a company town in Zimbabwe, transoceanic oral histories combined with autobiography, photo and video essays, a collaboratively created annotated bibliography on African and Afro-diasporic cinema, and much else. A queer feminist decolonial pedagogy insists on a freedom of forms, genres, and modalities to release thinking and writing from ossified, individualized modes of intellectual production, creating a small oasis of experimentation in the desert of directed training in singular disciplines.

**Sophie:** For our final assignment I chose to do an oral history interview with my grandmother on diasporic identity and experience,

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titled, *“Grandmother’s Portal: An Oral History of Life in Multiple Diasporas.”* This project represents to me a form of “epistemological decolonization” (Quijano, 2010). By elevating the life history and personhood of my grandmother through interviews, photographs and WhatsApp messages, I sought to work against the epistemological silencing and erasure of the stories of peoples harmed by colonialism; specifically in this case, the invisibility of the diasporic narratives of her homeplace, as well as the overextension of Eurocentric ways of knowing as universal. My project was rooted in the lived and living realities of the afterlife of British colonization in India as refracted through the polyphonic present of one elder’s life in diasporic London. In this piece, I took up one of our assigned course readings: Vilashini Cooppan’s (2019) model of memory as “connective tissue,” where memory unfolds within objects, bodies, places, and senses, interweaving disparate histories, geographies, identities, and entities. Though I could feel a distant call to archive my family’s stories, I did not see a place for this work in the academy, where the dominant mode of operation writhes away from the unsettling affective layers of personal inquiry. Our seminar offered a space where intimacy, affect, and relationality were valued grounds for knowledges, expanding the forms of inquiry I thought would be possible in my graduate training.

**Usha:**

One day, when it’s safe, when there’s no personal downside to calling a thing what it is, when it’s too late to hold anyone accountable, everyone will have always been against this.

Omar El Akkad (2025)

Early on the morning of June 5, 2024, a group of thirteen students and alumni occupied the president’s office. Campus and county police arrested them shortly after and took them to the county jail.<sup>5</sup> A number of our seminar participants waited outside the jail all day, pushing for bail, ensuring the arrested students had access to food and water, and were able to communicate with their friends and family.

Sophie and I found each other later that morning, watching with teary eyes the campus police rapidly dismantling the “People’s University for Palestine.” As the mostly immigrant workers packed up the beautifully painted posters, flags, free library books, tables, chairs, tents, and mattresses into trucks, all that remained on the site were two olive trees that students had planted a few weeks earlier.

Even as the encampment was under institutional attack, the well-resourced library had as its main display photos from a campus sit-in from 1977 demanding divestment from apartheid South Africa.<sup>6</sup> As photos of protests sat in the safety of a glass cabinet, students had been pushed into vans and taken to jail, then suspended for the rest of the year, and now charged with felonies by the county. It was clear that the carceral logics of the neoliberal university and the state have always gone hand in hand.

**Sophie:** University campuses are strategically curated to direct intellectual and affective energies toward settler colonial desires. The university co-opts revolutionary aims and packages them into institutionalized derivatives that dissipate transformative vision into near-sighted suites of programs and initiatives. When university members resist this to preserve the integrity of their struggles, they quickly come to experience the consequences of a university baring the truly punitive fangs that stay covered until you begin to resist their colonizing tendency. Just as the university disseminates state-regulated knowledge, it also regulates bodies as shown through the carceral responses to students, staff, and faculty who dare to hold institutions to account. Even with several universities around the world divesting, or partially divesting from companies complicit in genocide, a vast majority have ignored or rejected calls for increased transparency and accountability about their investment portfolio.

Commonly purported DEI values within neoliberal western universities contain contradictions, as they seek to “promote inclusion, belonging, and community,” yet render their students homeless and prohibit graduations for those taking action to demand the university’s divestment and disclosure. They “recognize and appreciate a wide range of cultural and global perspectives,” yet deny the humanity of those who offer them. They “respect differing opinions and backgrounds” until staff and student bodies ask that they interrogate their complicity in genocide.

**Usha:** Our “Decolonization and Decoloniality” seminar happened inside and out, spilling from the classroom to the streets, between walls and trees, in chairs and on grass. The tensions and joys from doing this work were marked by the jagged temporalities of academic work and freedom work during a time of significantly more activated campus politics in the US than in many decades. While course evaluations had some complaints about the “unconventional turn” the seminar took, many participants relayed how

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decolonial approaches strengthened their dedication to building networks of care and combat within academia. We had line danced in community, learned to dabke, treated the scholars on the syllabus as co-travelers, jostled with complex emotions around disagreement, and felt both unmoored and deeply anchored at different times.

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We have treated the classroom and our seminar here as an archive. An archive of affects, actions, disaffections, attachments. We archive so we will remember. As a guard against dismembering. As an invitation to re-member, to gather again and again in community, well beyond the end of any one course or professional degree. This return to the seminar is marked by a temporal back and forth movement as we think back to the classroom from a year ago, and while we still live through a time of genocide, within larger envelopes of extended occupation and extermination in the many parts of the world we each come from. We write this, alongside some of our seminar participants, as international academic workers under a second Trump administration, simultaneously cognizant of risk and privilege in this elite Global North private university. We write as one U.S. president threatens to build a riviera over the ruins created by another.

We model our queer feminist insurgent decolonial pedagogy on the Palestinian politics of the breach. Samera Esmeir (2024) asks: what will it take to breach the state's permanence and indefinite temporality? And responds with the politics of the breach, the daily resistance practices of violating state-marked territory by building houses without permits, throwing stones at checkpoints, and returning to one's village after being expelled. The decolonial classroom has the potential to breach the occupied epistemic zones of the academy and to soar toward fenced-off horizons if we are willing to do this risky and rewarding work as worker-scholar-combatants. The Palestinian spirit of *sumud* or steadfastness is a daily inspiration.

Notes

- 1 We recognize that we write as academic workers in an elite, private university, but since there has been repression of pro-Palestine speech across a range of U.S. universities, we hope that our focus on local conditions resonates in different ways for workers across a diverse range of educational institutions.
- 2 Sara Ahmed describes diversity initiatives as “a way of managing or containing conflict or dissent” (*On Being Included: Racism and Diversity in Institutional Life* (Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 2012), 13), while Priyamvada Gopal

notes that diversity can serve to militate against decolonization “if all it generates is a glib pluralism that allows the centre, and its attendant orthodoxies, to remain unchallenged and unchanged.” (“On Decolonisation and the University.” *Textual Practice* 35.6 (2021): 873–899.)

- 3 <https://www.kqed.org/news/12042881/as-stanford-hunger-strike-over-gaza-ends-students-say-protests-will-resume-next-year>
- 4 I expand on decolonial and liberatory pedagogy in “A Pedagogy of Generative Discomfort: Figuring the Film and Media Classroom as a Radical Space of Possibility” (forthcoming); “A Pedagogy of Reparations: Notes toward Repairing the Film and Media Studies Curriculum” *Feminist Media Histories*, 8(1), 2022: 181–193; and “Smuggling, Infiltrating, Usurping: Why Globalizing the Film and Media Studies Curriculum Is Essential to Decolonizing It.” *The Journal of Cinema and Media Studies* 61, no. 6 (2022).
- 5 See <https://www.nytimes.com/2024/06/05/us/stanford-protest-israel-gaza.html>
- 6 See <https://stanforddaily.com/2015/11/18/sit-ins-have-a-long-history-in-stanford-protests/>

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